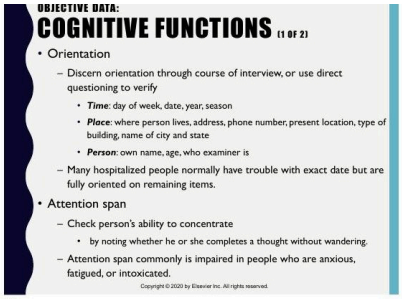
Head-to-Toe Check-off: Beginner Step-by-Step Guide (v4: highlighted items only)

NRSG 233 Health Assessment, LLU, Fall 2026. This is a personal practice guide, not an assignment. It covers **only the rubric items Luke highlighted** (25 assessments × 1.5 = **37.5 pts** of the 63), in rubric order: Mental Status, Head, Eyes, Ears, Nose, Mouth, Skin, Abdomen. Not included: Introduction/Safety, Motor, Sensory, Thorax & Lungs, Peripheral Vascular, Heart, and the pulse-scale bonus.

The rules (syllabus + rubric): Check-off in Week 9 (Nov 16–27), on a partner, recorded. **15-minute limit. No prompting:** −1 pt each time. You need **76%** to pass the course (a retake caps at 80%).
How each assessment is scored (1.5 pts): 0.25 for saying the NAME of the assessment out loud, **0.75** for the correct TECHNIQUE, **0.5** for stating FINDINGS in medical terms. So for every item: **1) Say what you're doing, 2) do it right, 3) say the normal finding out loud.**
Points in this guide: 25 × 1.5 = **37.5** (the full rubric is 63).
Technique words: INSPECT = look (and listen) carefully. PALPATE = feel with your fingers or hand. PERCUSS = tap to hear the tone. AUSCULTATE = listen with the stethoscope on bare skin.
Sources: her slides first (Module 1, Mental Status, Module 2 HEENT, Module 3 Skin, Module 4 Abdomen & MS). Jarvis 9e page numbers come from her doc sheets and the rubric's note to "refer to Jarvis." Photos labeled Jarvis are textbook photos. The two diagrams were drawn for this guide.

Mental Status (3 × 1.5 = 4.5 pts)

Technique: INSPECT (watch and listen, no touching)
Position / where you stand: Partner sits on the bed. You sit or stand facing them at eye level.



Her Mental Status slides: Cognitive functions

1. Orientation (3 assessments) — 1.5

① **Name it (0.25):** "I'm assessing orientation to person, place, and time."
② **Do it (0.75):** Ask 3 questions, one each for person, place, and time. Listen to whether the answers are correct and quick.

> **Say to partner:** "What is your name? Where are we right now? What is today's date?"

③ **State findings (0.5):** "Patient is alert and oriented ×3 to person, place, and time." (A&O×3)

> **Common mistake:** Asking only 2 questions, or saying "A&O" without the ×3.

[Her slides; Jarvis pp. 63, 67]



Her Mental Status slides: Cultural assessment

2. Culture (1 assessment) — 1.5

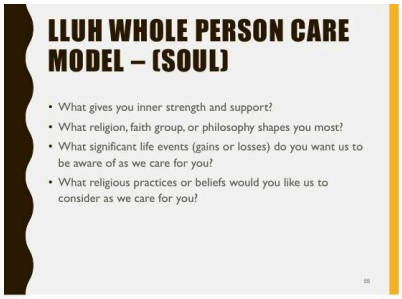
① **Name it (0.25):** "I'm doing a cultural assessment."
② **Do it (0.75):** Ask one open-ended question about cultural background or health practices.

> **Say to partner:** "Is there anything about your culture or background I should know to care for you?"

③ **State findings (0.5):** "Patient identifies as ___. No cultural practices affecting care." (State what they say.)

> **Common mistake:** Assuming their culture. Always ask.

[Her slides; doc sheet: Jarvis pp. 16–17]



Her slides: LLUH Whole Person Care (SOUL)

3. Spiritual (1 assessment) — 1.5

① **Name it (0.25):** "I'm doing a spiritual assessment."
② **Do it (0.75):** Ask one SOUL question (Sources of strength, Organized religion, Unique life events, Life practices).

> **Say to partner:** "What gives you inner strength and support?"

③ **State findings (0.5):** "Patient states ___ is a source of strength. No spiritual needs at this time."

> **Common mistake:** Pushing your own beliefs or asking a yes/no question.

[Her slides; doc sheet: Jarvis p. 17]

Head (1 × 1.5 = 1.5 pts)

Technique: INSPECT & PALPATE
Position / where you stand: Partner sits. Stand in front of them.


Jarvis p. 771 (photo)

4. Skull (size & symmetry) — 1.5

① **Name it (0.25):** "I'm inspecting and palpating the skull for size and symmetry."
② **Do it (0.75):** Look at the head from the front and sides. Then use the pads of your fingers to move the scalp in small circles, front to back, feeling for lumps or tenderness.

> **Say to partner:** "I'm going to feel your head. Tell me if anything is tender."

③ **State findings (0.5):** "Skull is normocephalic and symmetric. No lumps, lesions, or tenderness."

> **Common mistake:** Only looking (you must also palpate), or forgetting the word "normocephalic."

[Jarvis p. 259; Module 2 slides]

Eyes (5 × 1.5 = 7.5 pts)

Technique: INSPECT
Position / where you stand: Partner sits. You stand in front. For acuity, they stand 20 ft from the Snellen chart.


Jarvis p. 290 (photo)

5. Visual Acuity — 1.5

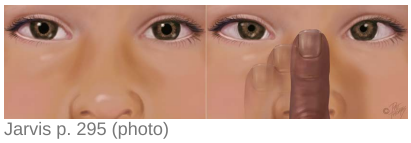
① **Name it (0.25):** "I'm testing visual acuity with the Snellen chart."
② **Do it (0.75):** Partner stands 20 ft away with glasses on if they wear them. Have them cover one eye with an occluder and read the smallest line they can. Repeat with the other eye.

> **Say to partner:** "Cover your left eye and read the smallest line you can."

③ **State findings (0.5):** "Visual acuity 20/20 in both eyes." (Read the fraction for the smallest line with ≤2 errors.)

> **Common mistake:** Partner pressing on the covered eye. Forgetting to test each eye separately.

[Her Module 2 slides; Jarvis pp. 289–290]


Jarvis p. 295 (photo)

6. Pupil Size & Shape — 1.5

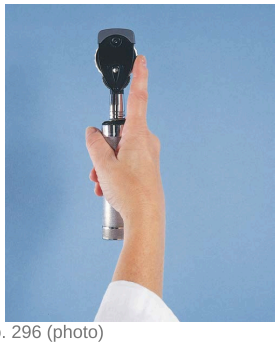
① **Name it (0.25):** "I'm inspecting pupil size and shape."
② **Do it (0.75):** Look at both pupils in normal room light and compare them.

> **Say to partner:** "Look straight ahead at the wall."

③ **State findings (0.5):** "Pupils are equal, round, about 3–5 mm."

> **Common mistake:** Not comparing the two sides.

[Her Module 2 slides; Jarvis p. 295]


Jarvis p. 296 (photo)

7. Direct Light Reflex — 1.5

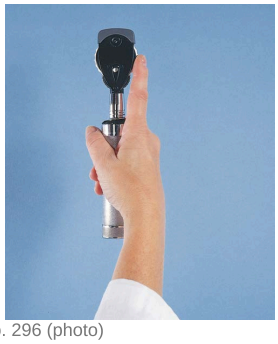
① **Name it (0.25):** "I'm testing the direct light reflex."
② **Do it (0.75):** Dim the light if you can. Bring the penlight in from the side (not straight on) into one eye. Watch the SAME pupil constrict. Do both eyes.

> **Say to partner:** "Keep looking at the wall. I'm going to shine a light in your eye."

③ **State findings (0.5):** "Direct light reflex present, brisk constriction bilaterally."

> **Common mistake:** Shining it straight on, which makes them focus on the light.

[Her Module 2 slides; Jarvis p. 295]



Jarvis p. 296 (photo)

8. Consensual Light Reflex

1.5

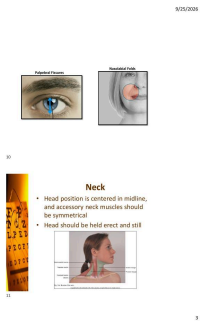
① **Name it (0.25):** "I'm testing the consensual light reflex."
② **Do it (0.75):** Shine the light into one eye and watch the OPPOSITE pupil. It should constrict too. Do both sides.

Say to partner: "Keep looking ahead."

③ **State findings (0.5):** "Consensual light reflex present bilaterally."

Common mistake: Watching the wrong eye.

[Her Module 2 slides; Jarvis p. 295]



Her Module 2 HEENT slides (eyes)

9. Accommodation

1.5

① **Name it (0.25):** "I'm testing accommodation."
② **Do it (0.75):** Have them look at the far wall, then quickly at your finger held about 7–8 cm from their nose. The pupils should constrict and the eyes converge.

Say to partner: "Look at the wall... now look at my finger."

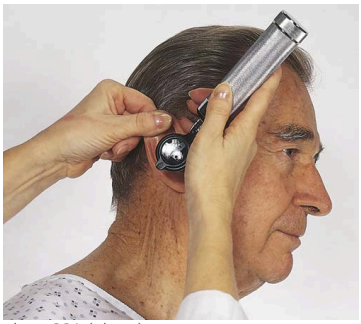
③ **State findings (0.5):** "Accommodation present: pupils constrict and eyes converge. PERRLA."

Common mistake: Holding your finger too far away.

[Her Module 2 slides; Jarvis p. 295]

Ears (2 × 1.5 = 3 pts)

Technique: INSPECT; INSPECT & PALPATE
Position / where you stand: Partner sits. Stand at their side.



Jarvis p. 331 (photo)

10. External Auditory Meatus

1.5

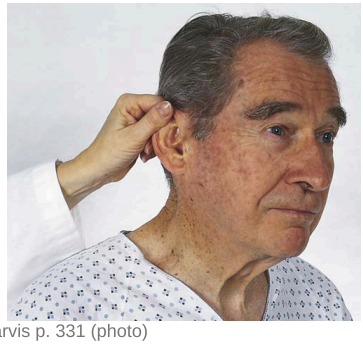
① **Name it (0.25):** "I'm inspecting the external auditory meatus."
② **Do it (0.75):** Look into the ear opening with a penlight or otoscope. In adults, gently pull the auricle up and back.

Say to partner: "I'm going to look inside your ear."

③ **State findings (0.5):** "Meatus is patent, no discharge, redness, or swelling. Small amount of cerumen."

Common mistake: Pulling the ear down (that's for children).

[Her Module 2 slides; Jarvis p. 331]



Jarvis p. 331 (photo)

11. External Ear

1.5

① **Name it (0.25):** "I'm inspecting and palpating the external ear."
② **Do it (0.75):** Look at the size, shape, and skin. Move the auricle and press the tragus.

Say to partner: "Tell me if this hurts."

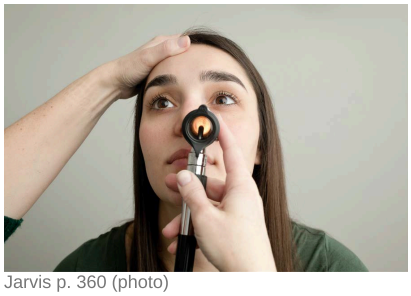
③ **State findings (0.5):** "Auricles symmetric, skin intact, no lesions. Nontender to palpation."

Common mistake: Only looking (you must also palpate).

[Her Module 2 slides; Jarvis p. 331]

Nose (2 × 1.5 = 3 pts)

Technique: INSPECT & PALPATE; INSPECT
Position / where you stand: Partner sits. Stand in front.


Jarvis p. 360 (photo)

12. External Nose

1.5

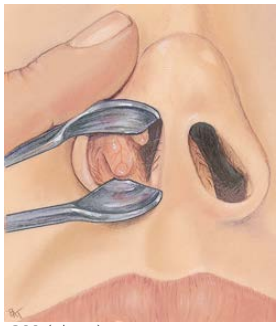
① **Name it (0.25):** "I'm inspecting and palpating the external nose."
② **Do it (0.75):** Look for symmetry, deformity, and lesions. Gently palpate down the bridge.

Say to partner: "I'm going to gently feel your nose."

③ **State findings (0.5):** "Nose is symmetric and midline. No deformity, lesions, or tenderness."

Common mistake: Skipping the palpation.

[Her Module 2 slides; Jarvis p. 360]


Jarvis p. 360 (photo)

13. Patency of Nostrils

1.5

① **Name it (0.25):** "I'm testing patency of the nostrils."
② **Do it (0.75):** Press one nostril closed with your finger. Have them close their mouth and sniff. Then do the other side.

Say to partner: "Close your mouth and sniff in through your nose."

③ **State findings (0.5):** "Both nares are patent."

Common mistake: Closing both sides at once.

[Her Module 2 slides; Jarvis p. 360]

Mouth (4 × 1.5 = 6 pts)

Technique: INSPECT
Position / where you stand: Partner sits. Use a penlight and tongue blade. Put on gloves.


Jarvis p. 362 (photo)

14. Lips

1.5

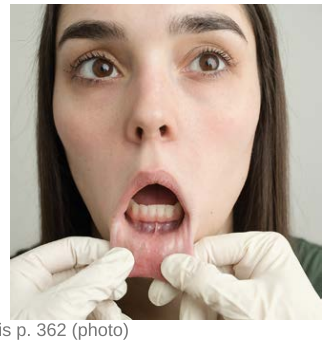
① **Name it (0.25):** "I'm inspecting the lips."
② **Do it (0.75):** Look at the color, moisture, and any cracks or lesions.

Say to partner: "Relax your lips for me."

③ **State findings (0.5):** "Lips are pink, moist, smooth, and symmetric. No lesions."

Common mistake: Forgetting to say the color.

[Her Module 2 slides; Jarvis p. 362]


Jarvis p. 362 (photo)

15. Gums

1.5

① **Name it (0.25):** "I'm inspecting the gums."
② **Do it (0.75):** Use the tongue blade to move the lips and cheeks aside. Shine the light.

Say to partner: "Open your mouth for me."

③ **State findings (0.5):** "Gums pink, moist, firm, no swelling or bleeding."

Common mistake: Doing it without gloves or light.

[Her Module 2 slides; Jarvis p. 364]


Jarvis p. 364 (photo)

16. Teeth

1.5

① **Name it (0.25):** "I'm inspecting the teeth."
② **Do it (0.75):** Look for missing, loose, or decayed teeth.
Say to partner: "Show me your teeth."
③ **State findings (0.5):** "Teeth are white, smooth, and aligned. No caries or missing teeth."
Common mistake: N/A
[Her Module 2 slides; Jarvis p. 364]


Jarvis p. 364 (photo)

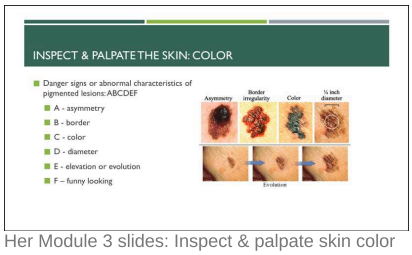
17. Tongue

1.5

① **Name it (0.25):** "I'm inspecting the tongue."
② **Do it (0.75):** Have them stick out their tongue. Look at the top, then the underside.
Say to partner: "Stick out your tongue... now touch the roof of your mouth."
③ **State findings (0.5):** "Tongue pink, moist, midline. No lesions."
Common mistake: Forgetting the underside.
[Her Module 2 slides; Jarvis p. 364]

Skin (4 × 1.5 = 6 pts)

Technique: INSPECT (color); PALPATE (temp, edema, moisture)
Position / where you stand: Partner sits. Use their hands, arms, and shins.

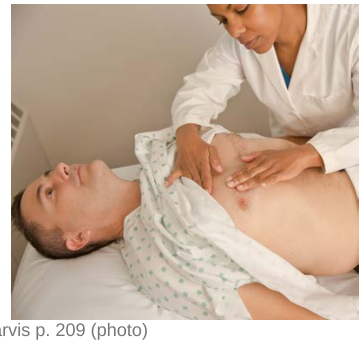


Her Module 3 slides: Inspect & palpate skin color

18. Color

1.5

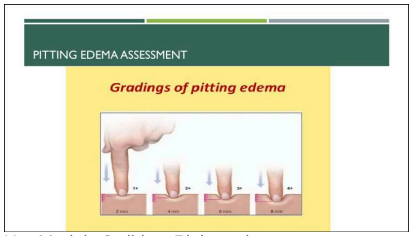
① **Name it (0.25):** "I'm inspecting skin color."
② **Do it (0.75):** Look at the face, arms, hands, and nail beds in good light.
Say to partner: "Let me look at your arms and hands."
③ **State findings (0.5):** "Skin color consistent with ethnicity, even pigmentation. No pallor, cyanosis, or jaundice."
Common mistake: N/A
[Her slides; doc sheet: Jarvis p. 207]


Jarvis p. 209 (photo)

19. Temperature

1.5

① **Name it (0.25):** "I'm palpating skin temperature."
② **Do it (0.75):** Use the BACK of your hand (it's most sensitive to temperature) on their arms and legs, comparing both sides.
Say to partner: "I'm going to feel your skin with the back of my hand."
③ **State findings (0.5):** "Skin warm to touch bilaterally."
Common mistake: Using your fingertips.
[Her slides; doc sheet: Jarvis pp. 209–210]

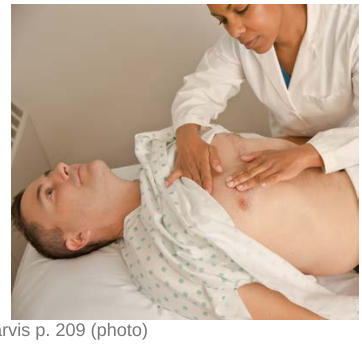


Her Module 3 slides: Pitting edema

20. Edema

1.5

① **Name it (0.25):** "I'm palpating for edema."
② **Do it (0.75):** Press firmly with your thumb over the shin (tibia) or the top of the foot for 5 seconds, release, and look for a dent.
Say to partner: "I'm going to press on your shin for a few seconds."
③ **State findings (0.5):** "No edema. Nonpitting." (If present, grade it 1+ to 4+.)
Common mistake: Pressing for only 1 second.
[Her slides; doc sheet: Jarvis pp. 210, 519]



Jarvis p. 209 (photo)

21. Moisture

1.5

① **Name it (0.25):** "I'm palpating skin moisture."
② **Do it (0.75):** Feel the skin surface with your fingertips.

Say to partner: N/A

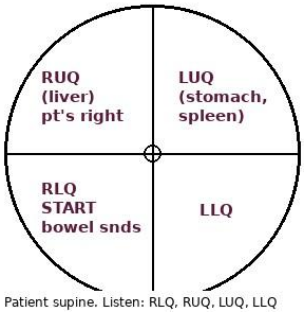
③ **State findings (0.5):** "Skin dry and intact."

Common mistake: N/A

[Her slides; doc sheet: Jarvis p. 210]

Abdomen (4 × 1.5 = 6 pts)

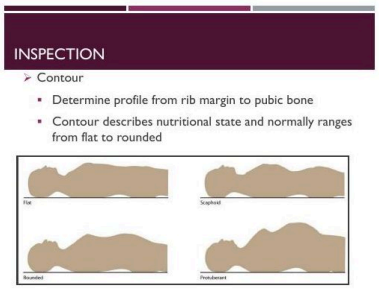
Technique: Order: INSPECT, AUSCULTATE, PERCUSS, PALPATE (listen before you touch!)
Position / where you stand: Partner supine and flat, arms at sides, knees slightly bent, bladder emptied. Drape. Stand on their RIGHT. Warm your hands and stethoscope.



Drawn diagram: the 4 quadrants (the patient's right is on YOUR left as you face them)

Quadrant map

Draw imaginary lines through the umbilicus, one vertical and one horizontal. RUQ = liver. LUQ = stomach and spleen. Bowel sounds start in the RLQ.



Her Module 4 slides: Inspection

22. Abdominal contour

1.5

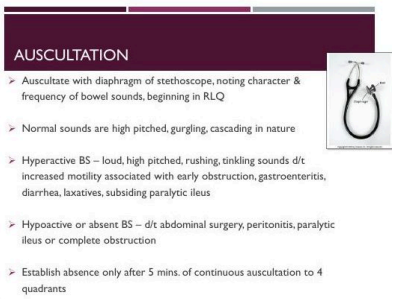
① **Name it (0.25):** "I'm inspecting abdominal contour."
② **Do it (0.75):** Stand or bend at their side and look across the abdomen from the rib margin to the pubic bone.

Say to partner: "Lie flat with your arms at your sides."

③ **State findings (0.5):** "Abdomen flat (or rounded) and symmetric. Umbilicus midline. No visible masses or pulsations."

Common mistake: Looking only from above.

[Her slides; doc sheet: Jarvis p. 542]



Her Module 4 slides: Auscultation

23. Bowel Sounds

1.5

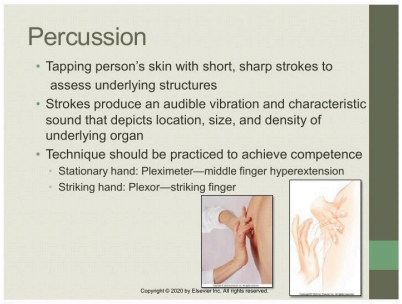
① **Name it (0.25):** "I'm auscultating bowel sounds."
② **Do it (0.75):** Put the diaphragm lightly on the skin. **Start in the RLQ**, then RUQ, LUQ, LLQ (see the diagram on the abdomen page).

Say to partner: "I'm going to listen to your belly. Breathe normally."

③ **State findings (0.5):** "Bowel sounds active in all 4 quadrants: high-pitched, gurgling." (Absent only after 5 min of listening.)

Common mistake: Palpating before you listen. Starting in the wrong quadrant.

[Her slides; doc sheet: Jarvis p. 545]



Her Module 1 slides: Percussion

24. Abdomen (general tone)

1.5

① **Name it (0.25):** "I'm percussing the abdomen for general tone."

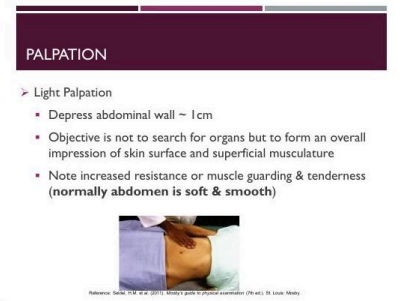
② **Do it (0.75):** Indirect percussion: put the middle finger of your non-dominant hand flat on the skin (only that finger touching). Tap its last joint twice with the tip of your other middle finger, snapping from the wrist. Do all 4 quadrants.

Say to partner: "You'll feel some tapping."

③ **State findings (0.5):** "Tympany predominates in all 4 quadrants."

Common mistake: Resting your whole hand on the abdomen, which muffles the sound. (Her slides: don't do liver span.)

[Jarvis p. 546; her Module 4 slides]



Her Module 4 slides: Light palpation

25. Abdomen (all 4 quadrants)

1.5

① **Name it (0.25):** "I'm performing light palpation of all 4 quadrants."

② **Do it (0.75):** Use the pads of 4 fingers together and press only about 1 cm in, with gentle circles, through all 4 quadrants. Watch their face. Do any tender spot last.

Say to partner: "Tell me if anything is tender. I'll be gentle."

③ **State findings (0.5):** "Abdomen soft and nontender in all 4 quadrants. No masses or guarding."

Common mistake: Pressing too deep (light is about 1 cm). Not watching their face.

[Her slides; doc sheet: Jarvis p. 548]

One-page checklist: highlighted rubric items (rubric order). For every item: NAME it, DO it, STATE findings. 15 min, no prompting.

#	Topic	Item	Pts	✓
1	Mental Status	Orientation (3 assessments)	1.5	☐
2	Mental Status	Culture (1 assessment)	1.5	☐
3	Mental Status	Spiritual (1 assessment)	1.5	☐
4	Head	Skull (size & symmetry)	1.5	☐
5	Eyes	Visual Acuity	1.5	☐
6	Eyes	Pupil Size & Shape	1.5	☐
7	Eyes	Direct Light Reflex	1.5	☐
8	Eyes	Consensual Light Reflex	1.5	☐
9	Eyes	Accommodation	1.5	☐
10	Ears	External Auditory Meatus	1.5	☐
11	Ears	External Ear	1.5	☐
12	Nose	External Nose	1.5	☐
13	Nose	Patency of Nostrils	1.5	☐
14	Mouth	Lips	1.5	☐
15	Mouth	Gums	1.5	☐
16	Mouth	Teeth	1.5	☐
17	Mouth	Tongue	1.5	☐
18	Skin	Color	1.5	☐
19	Skin	Temperature	1.5	☐
20	Skin	Edema	1.5	☐
21	Skin	Moisture	1.5	☐
22	Abdomen	Abdominal contour	1.5	☐
23	Abdomen	Bowel Sounds	1.5	☐
24	Abdomen	Abdomen (general tone)	1.5	☐
25	Abdomen	Abdomen (all 4 quadrants)	1.5	☐
Total (highlighted items)			**37.5**	